

THE DELHI DURBAR

The 'GenNext' leaders are all senior to the party president



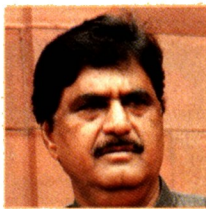
ARUN JAITLEY, 57
Leader of the Opposition
in Rajya Sabha



SUSHMA SWARAJ, 57
Leader of the Opposition
in Lok Sabha



VENKAIAH NAIDU, 60
Rajya Sabha MP and
former party president



GOPINATH MUNDE, 60
Deputy Leader in
Lok Sabha

POLITICS IS THE SUM OF INDIVIDUAL ASPIRATIONS and Jaitley and Swaraj are PM-aspirants. It remains to be seen if Gadkari finds room to create an impression.

TEAM GADKARI

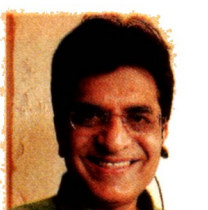
Yet in the making, the team shows a bias for youth and diversity



MANOHAR PARRIKAR
Former CM, Goa



VASUNDHARA RAJE
Former CM, Rajasthan



KIRIT SOMAIYA
National Executive Member



ANANTH KUMAR
General Secretary



PIYUSH GOYAL
Treasurer, Maharashtra



RAVI SHANKAR PRASAD
MP and spokesperson



SHAHNAWAZ HUSSAIN,
MP and former minister



V. SAHASRABUDHE
Training Cell, BJP

Indeed, Modi is among the first few he conferred with before taking on the new assignment. It is a friendship based on a common commitment to Hindutva, a love for vegetarian food, theories of good governance and what he calls *aar paar ki ladaai*. Contrary to perceptions about him being a technocrat more than a politician, Gadkari is a regular rabble-rouser and loves nothing more than a good battle. Throughout his tenure as leader of the

Opposition, Gadkari led the campaign against farmer suicides, corruption in Wakf boards and exposed Congressmen involved in the Telgi scam.

Elected first in 1989 to the Maharashtra Legislative Council, he rose to fame, following his induction as public works minister in 1995. In a country where projects seem to have a flawed DNA and are coded for delays and cost overruns, Gadkari found ways to deliver on time. He innovated financing,

dumped over 70 fossilised government regulations and campaigned for new technology. When a Shiv Sena mayor in Mumbai blocked the clearance for a flyover, he drove to the residence of Bal Thackeray and got a clearance the same night. When Reliance Industries put the cost of the Mumbai-Pune Expressway at Rs 3,600 crore, he fought with Pramod Mahajan and said the Public Works Department (PWD) could do it and built it at a cost of less than Rs 1,600 crore. The secret, says BJP leader Atul Bhatkalkar, is "a talent for working out details and the confidence to empower fellow workers". Obviously, the lessons learnt in executing the projects and bulldozing naysayers will all come into play.

Gadkari will need both the collaborative and combative faculties to face the challenges, the biggest of which will be to maintain the identity of the party while yet toeing the RSS line. At an operational level, the BJP is in a complete shambles, symbolised by raging factional battles across states. Fortunately, for Gadkari there are no major polls immediately so there will be no major debacles. As the president of the principal Opposition party, he has the opportunity and the responsibility to challenge the Congress-led Government. Development as a political plank is alluring but it will require articulation and a stand on controversial issues like privatisation, opening up retail and FDI caps. It also requires alignment between the parliamentary party and the organisation, between the intellectual idea and mass mobilisation. This calls for skilled alliance building.

He may want to refer to Maratha history for help. The greatest expansion of the Maratha empire was under the Peshwas, enabled by Baji Rao I who led a coalition of armies of Holkars, Shinde, Bhonsale, Gaekwad and others to conquer Delhi. If Gadkari wants the BJP to be nationally relevant again, he will have to find that one idea and mount a similar campaign. Failure will only accelerate the speed at which the party is declining.

with Malini Bhupta and Bhavna Vij Aurora